COMPENDIUM #77

HOW ELITES FUCKED HUMANITY

An Exposé of Corporate, Political, and Religious Greed

Trevor Swistchew 2026 — Compendium #77 — Political Economy & Social Critique

MOVEMENT I: THE NOBLE WRAP & THE ALTAR OF STATE

The history of humanity is often presented as a glorious story of civilization, progress, kings, presidents, prophets, nations and empires. Yet beneath the monuments, flags, palaces, cathedrals and corporate headquarters lies another story. It is the story of ordinary people paying the price while powerful groups compete for wealth, authority and influence. The names change. The uniforms change. The slogans change. The mechanisms remain remarkably similar.

Throughout history, elites have often justified their power by claiming divine approval, racial superiority, ideological certainty, economic necessity, national destiny or historical inevitability. They have rarely announced that they seek power for its own sake. Instead, power is almost always wrapped in noble language. Wars are framed as liberation. Taxation is framed as duty. Conquest is framed as civilization. Repression is framed as security. Religious obedience is framed as salvation.

The nineteenth-century historian Lord Acton issued one of history's most famous warnings: "Power tends to corrupt and absolute power corrupts absolutely." He argued that political and religious authorities must be judged by the same moral standards as everyone else and that holders of power deserve greater scrutiny, not less.

That warning was not directed at one religion, one government or one ideology. It was directed at a recurring tendency within human institutions themselves.

Religion has often inspired compassion, charity, education, art and social reform. Yet religious institutions have also been used as instruments of political authority. Across centuries, rulers sought legitimacy from priests and clerics, while religious authorities often gained protection and privilege from rulers. The result was a mutually beneficial alliance between throne and altar. People were frequently encouraged to obey earthly authority by being told that authority reflected divine will.

European history provides countless examples. Monarchs claimed divine right. Churches blessed armies marching to battle. Rival Christian factions slaughtered one another during the Wars of Religion. The Crusades were justified through sacred claims. Heretics were persecuted. Dissenters were silenced. Religious institutions that preached peace sometimes sanctioned violence when their own influence was threatened.

The pattern was never unique to Christianity. Similar dynamics appeared throughout civilizations. Political leaders discovered that ideas are often more powerful than swords. An army can occupy a city. A belief system can occupy a mind.

This does not prove that all religion is false. It proves that institutions built around belief can be exploited by ambitious individuals.

MOVEMENT II: SECULAR DOGMA & THE MEAT GRINDER OF WAR

The same dynamic appears in politics. Political ideologies frequently claim to represent the people while concentrating power among a narrow class. Monarchies claimed kings ruled by God's will. Communist dictatorships claimed they ruled on behalf of workers. Fascist governments claimed they embodied the nation. Colonial empires claimed they brought civilization. In every case, ordinary people were often asked to sacrifice while leaders accumulated power.

The twentieth century offered horrifying examples of what can happen when power escapes accountability. Tens of millions died under Nazi rule. Tens of millions more died under Stalin's Soviet regime and Mao's China. Entire populations suffered under systems that claimed historical necessity justified human suffering. Grand theories became excuses for mass death.

The lesson is not that one ideology is uniquely evil. The lesson is that concentrated power combined with unquestionable certainty creates conditions where atrocity becomes possible.

The victims are rarely members of ruling elites. They are farmers, workers, labourers and families who find themselves trapped between competing centres of power.

War provides perhaps the clearest example of this reality.

Generals issue commands. Politicians make declarations. Corporate contractors secure deals. Ordinary soldiers enter trenches. The poor have traditionally fought wars designed by the powerful. History is littered with cemeteries filled not with kings and financiers but with labourers, miners, factory workers and conscripts.

This reality inspired U.S. President Dwight D. Eisenhower, himself a military commander, to warn in his 1961 farewell address about what he called the "military-industrial complex." He cautioned citizens against the acquisition of unwarranted influence by the alliance between military institutions and arms industries.

Eisenhower was not a radical critic of capitalism. He was a former supreme military commander and president. His warning carried weight precisely because it came from within the establishment itself.

MOVEMENT III: THE TRILLION-DOLLAR LEDGER & MANUFACTURED HUNGER

More than six decades later, military expenditure continues to climb. The Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) reported that global military spending reached approximately $2.718 trillion in 2024, the highest level ever recorded by the organization.

Supporters argue military spending is necessary for security. Critics argue enormous resources are diverted into warfare while problems such as poverty, healthcare, housing, education and infrastructure remain inadequately addressed. Regardless of where one stands politically, the scale of military expenditure demonstrates how power remains concentrated in institutions connected to conflict.

The consequences extend beyond battlefields.

The United Nations and the World Food Programme repeatedly identify conflict as a primary driver of hunger worldwide. The World Food Programme states that conflict drives most of the world's major food

crises and notes that armed conflict and violence remain the principal drivers of acute food insecurity in most identified hunger hotspots.

The relationship between power struggles and human suffering is therefore not abstract.

Wars destroy farms. Wars disrupt trade. Wars displace populations. Wars increase hunger. Wars spread disease. Wars consume resources that might otherwise improve living standards.

When leaders speak of strategic interests, those interests often translate into shattered lives for people who possessed little influence over the original decisions.

MOVEMENT IV: CORPORATE FEUDALISM & THE MANUFACTURED CONSENSUS

Alongside political and military power stands corporate power.

Modern corporations have generated unprecedented prosperity, scientific advances and technological achievements. Yet they have also created new concentrations of wealth that raise profound questions about democracy and accountability.

According to Oxfam's analysis, the richest one percent captured nearly two-thirds of new wealth created between 2020 and 2022. Oxfam further reported that billionaire fortunes expanded dramatically while many people faced rising costs and economic hardship.

Reasonable people can debate Oxfam's policy conclusions. What is difficult to deny is that wealth has become increasingly concentrated.

When wealth becomes highly concentrated, influence often follows.

Political campaigns require funding. Lobbying requires funding. Media ownership requires funding. Think tanks require funding. Influence requires resources.

Extreme concentrations of wealth create conditions where some voices inevitably become louder than others. Oxfam has argued that billionaire influence increasingly shapes economic and political outcomes and that major corporations wield extraordinary power over global decision-making.

Again, the issue is not whether every wealthy person is corrupt. The issue is structural. When vast power accumulates in relatively few hands, accountability becomes more difficult.

This concern reaches beyond corporations and includes governments themselves. Governments possess powers no corporation can match. They command police forces, intelligence agencies, prisons, taxation systems and armed forces. Throughout history, governments have often expanded authority during crises.

Sometimes this expansion is necessary. Sometimes it persists long after the emergency has ended. Citizens are frequently told restrictions are temporary. History suggests temporary powers often become permanent features of government.

This is why free societies place such importance on independent courts, free media, civil liberties and transparent institutions. They act as barriers against the concentration of authority.

Yet elites frequently portray criticism as disloyalty.

Questioning war can be labelled unpatriotic. Questioning corporations can be called anti-business. Questioning religious institutions can be labelled blasphemous. Questioning governments can be described as extremism.

The message remains similar: do not challenge the people in charge.

History strongly suggests the opposite lesson. Challenge them constantly. Not because every leader is corrupt. Because no leader is immune from corruption.

The problem becomes even more dangerous when political authority fuses with certainty.

Religious certainty has justified persecution. Nationalist certainty has justified conquest. Ideological certainty has justified dictatorship. Economic certainty has justified exploitation.

Once a leadership class becomes convinced it possesses absolute truth, compromise becomes weakness and dissent becomes a threat. Humanity's most destructive episodes often emerged not from uncertainty but from certainty.

The inquisitor was certain. The fascist was certain. The revolutionary executioner was certain. The dictator was certain.

The certainty differed. The consequences often looked remarkably similar.

MOVEMENT V: THE LABOUR THAT BUILDS SOCIETY & THE DEMAND FOR ACCOUNTABILITY

Meanwhile ordinary people continued working, raising children, paying taxes, building roads, growing food and keeping societies functioning.

History is full of rulers claiming greatness while depending entirely upon populations whose labour sustained them.

Without workers, there is no economy. Without farmers, there is no food. Without engineers, there is no infrastructure. Without nurses, there is no healthcare. Without teachers, there is no education.

Yet these groups rarely dominate national decision-making. Instead, influence often gravitates toward those already possessing wealth and institutional connections.

This imbalance creates a persistent illusion that elites create society. In reality, society is a collective achievement. Elites manage parts of it. Ordinary people build most of it.

Powerful groups frequently compete against one another rather than cooperate.

Corporations compete. Governments compete. Religious institutions compete. Political parties compete. Billionaires compete.

Their actions nevertheless produce a common result: ordinary people frequently bear the costs of elite competition.

The worker loses employment. The citizen loses freedoms. The refugee loses a home. The soldier loses a limb. The civilian loses family members. The taxpayer funds the consequences.

One of the greatest tricks in history has been persuading populations that their interests are identical to those of elites.

A king says the kingdom is under threat. A corporation says regulation threatens prosperity. A political faction says democracy itself depends upon victory. A religious authority says salvation requires obedience.

Sometimes these claims contain truth. Often they conceal self interest.

The responsibility of citizens is not blind acceptance or blind rejection. It is scrutiny. Power should never receive automatic trust. Trust should be earned through transparency, accountability and evidence.

This principle applies equally to priests, politicians, billionaires, activists, generals and corporations.

No institution should be beyond criticism. No ideology should be beyond examination. No authority should be above evidence.

The greatest advances in human history emerged not because elites voluntarily surrendered power but because ordinary people demanded accountability.

Workers organized. Citizens protested. Journalists investigated. Scientists challenged orthodoxy. Dissidents spoke openly. Reformers exposed corruption.

The true lesson of history is therefore not that every elite figure is evil nor that every institution is corrupt. The lesson is more important. Human beings are fallible. Power magnifies the consequences of that fallibility.

Whether clothed in religious garments, military uniforms, expensive suits or political office, concentrated power repeatedly demonstrates the need for vigilance, criticism and accountability.

Lord Acton's warning remains relevant because it addresses a permanent feature of human society. Power attracts those who desire it. Some use it responsibly. Others abuse it. Institutions that cannot be questioned become dangerous.

The challenge facing humanity is not merely to replace one elite with another. History shows that new rulers frequently imitate the behaviours of those they replace. The challenge is creating systems where power remains answerable to the people affected by it.

That task remains unfinished.

Wars continue. Hunger continues. Extreme inequality continues. Religious manipulation continues. Political propaganda continues. Corporate influence continues.

The faces change. The temptation remains.

The story of humanity is not simply the story of those in power. It is also the story of billions of ordinary people whose labour built civilizations, whose taxes financed governments, whose beliefs empowered institutions and whose sacrifices filled battlefields.

The greatest danger arises when elites forget this truth and imagine they are superior, uniquely enlightened or entitled to rule without challenge.

History's verdict on such arrogance is severe.

Empires collapse. Regimes fall. Institutions disintegrate. Fortunes vanish.

Only the consequences remain. The consequences are usually paid for by the very people who held the least power in creating them.

HISTORICAL & ARCHIVAL REFERENCES

1. Lord Acton (John Dalberg-Acton), Letter to Bishop Mandell Creighton (April 5, 1887) — 'Power tends to corrupt and absolute power corrupts absolutely. Great men are almost always bad men, even when they exercise influence and not authority.'
2. Dwight D. Eisenhower, Farewell Address to the Nation (January 17, 1961) — Official presidential warning regarding the acquisition of unwarranted influence by the military-industrial complex.
3. Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI), Trends in World Military Expenditure 2024 (April 2025 Fact Sheet) — Documenting global military spending reaching an all-time high of $2.718 trillion.
4. United Nations World Food Programme (WFP), Conflict and Hunger Briefings & Global Reports on Food Crises (2024–2025) — Identifying armed conflict and violence as the primary drivers of acute hunger, famine, and displacement worldwide.
5. United Nations Food Systems Summit & Famine Prevention Briefings — Breaking the Vicious Circle of Hunger and Armed Conflict.
6. Oxfam International, Survival of the Richest: How We Must Tax the Extreme Rich to Tackle Inequality (2023–2025) — Documenting that the richest 1% captured nearly two-thirds of all new wealth created globally between 2020 and 2022.

Copyright — Trevor Swistchew 2026. All rights reserved. — Compendium #77